

Something amazing this way comes

This time around, I'm going to touch upon a theme that's been pretty popular for columns here at Digit, except – finally – I find myself in a position to be able to take a diametrically different view. Many of the editors and columnists in the past have often wondered, with quite a bit of disappointment, at the dearth of technology that truly amazes us. The common gripe has always been that everything is only an increment over the previous generation – whether it be a higher resolution screen, a more efficient CPU or even a bigger phone (*ahem* iPhone 6) – and those of us in the industry rarely get taken in by the hype. We wistfully long for the tech that can truly amaze and excite us; tech that we rarely get to experience. Where are the leaps and bounds? Where is the revolution?

Well it's coming.

And it's in the form of Virtual Reality (VR). If you're even remotely involved with tech, you've probably read or heard this proclamation before. But, before labelling me Captain Obvious and turning the page, I'd like you to stay with me, if only for a bit, and try to understand why I'm stating the seemingly obvious.

Most people who've read about VR are usually polarised into two camps. One set envisions the possibilities based on futuristic movies they've seen or science fiction they've read, and think of the unreal. And the other group remembers the shoddy "Virtual Reality" or "5D Experience" they had at amusement parks and go "meh, it's probably an iterative increment over that". I'm here to tell you that it's not.

By some estimates, there are only about 75,000 Oculus Rift kits floating around in the hands of the general populace all over the world. Even fewer of those would be the DK2 revision that I got to try recently. And the experience was revelatory. If you're one of the few who got a chance to try the rollercoaster demo on the DK1 in malls, don't judge it based on that strictly-work-in-progress prototype; the experience on the DK2 isn't comparable.

The trouble with reporting my experience with the Oculus headset is that it's extremely difficult to describe. I'm limited to mere words. Pictures and videos (for once) are utterly useless. I can't just put in a shorturl and expect you to truly "get" what I'm talking about. You have

to experience it for yourself; there's no other way. You just wouldn't know what it's like to be able to peer around corners by merely craning your neck, to have free-look capabilities in a digitally constructed world surrounding you, to be able to do barrel rolls in a space simulator (like EVE: Valkyrie) without being sick; it's quite something.

While 3D was a gimmick, VR (and Oculus as a first-to-market proof of concept) is not. Back when everyone cribbed about not wanting to wear dorky glasses to enjoy a film in 3D in their living rooms, I sagely nodded my head in agreement. 3D was more like a studio and manufacturer fuelled boom – for an industry clutching at straws to bring something new to bored consumers. Virtual Reality, on the other hand, works. Throw enough graphics processing power at it to bring down latency even further and bring up the megapixel count for the head-mounted display screens and it will have arrived sooner than you can say "Entering Quest World". And yes, in case you're wondering, I wouldn't mind wearing a bulky HMD on my face for a couple of hours a day, because the difference in the experience isn't incremental. It's exponential.

Some of the smartest people in the world believe VR is the future. John Carmack (of Doom fame) jumped onto Oculus very early and has had a significant hand in taking it where it is today. Mark Zuckerberg believed in it so much that he put \$2 billion behind his bet. Talk about voting with your wallet. Most people were bewildered about why Facebook decided to stick a finger in this pie, but now that I've experienced the possibilities for myself, I agree with Zuck. It is indeed the "next major computing platform," and makes complete sense for Facebook to enter the game early. Technology is getting social, and immersive virtual experiences of different sorts will become commonplace in the years to come. More on that in the article we've planned for the next month. For now, here's the bottom line: VR is coming and it's not just going to change the way we play games, but a whole lot of other things. 



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Got feedback about this column?
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